it was only three months before Kamran was marching at a very living Humayun once again. This time, he took Akbar with him.

Perhaps it was knowing this – and fearing how his son might be treated, now that he was no longer protected by infancy – that Humayun tried to prevent a battle.[50] He sent Kamran an envoy proposing peace and tempting him with a joint conquest of Hindustan. Kamran's reply was that they must sort out their Afghan holdings first: Let Humayun keep Qandahar and return Kabul to Kamran, only then would he join the march to Hindustan.

Humayun suggested a tweak to the arrangement: how would Kamran like to marry his daughter to Akbar, and let the boy have Kabul while the brothers marched south? 'Both Kabul and Hindustan would then . . . belong to the two of [us],' the emperor concluded with disingenuous satisfaction.

Not surprisingly, negotiations broke down; battle was joined and swiftly lost by Kamran, who fled the scene. He left Akbar behind, as also two camels carrying Humayun's books – lost in the battle of the missing jubba. Both reunions gave the emperor great joy; his brother's prospects were dimming, meanwhile.

The defeat didn't break Kamran's spirit, but it did reduce his circumstances. His brother Askari, who had drifted back to Kamran's side, was caught by Humayun and promptly exiled.[51] In fact, very little of Kamran's army seems to have survived the battle un-killed, uncaptured or undeterred: he had no more than eight men with him when he fled. A year or so later, he had only managed to gather enough warriors for night raids, not wars. Even so, it was a raid that would hurt Humayun – and Kamran, too; the whole family, in fact – more than any previous battle between the brothers.

'The night was dark,' writes Abul Fazl. News of a raid had reached Humayun's camp earlier that evening; the men were on guard, Humayun and Akbar had ridden up a hill, from where they kept watch. It was November, and cold. Hindal, the youngest, was wearing a greatcoat on top of his armour, and a black fur hat.

Kamran and his men stormed the camp, and Hindal rode out to the trenches. He heard a voice calling for help – it was Hindal's *tabaqchi*, his master of plate (or loosely, his waiter). Ever gallant, Hindal got off his horse. In the darkness and confusion, no one followed him; and two of